

Department of Applied Mathematics and Statistics
COLORADO SCHOOL OF MINES
 MATH 455: Partial Differential Equations

Assignment #3 - Wave Equation
 Due Tuesday, October 6, 2026

1. (15 points) Define the functions

$$f(x) = \begin{cases} x, & \text{if } 0 \leq x \leq 1 \\ 1, & \text{if } 1 < x < 5 \\ 6 - x, & \text{if } 5 \leq x \leq 6 \\ 0, & \text{else,} \end{cases}$$

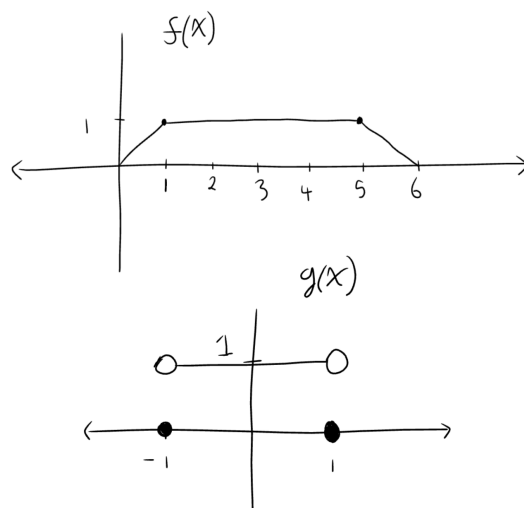
$$g(x) = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } |x| < 1 \\ 0, & \text{else,} \end{cases}$$

and consider solutions of the wave equation

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial t^2} - c^2 \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} = 0. \quad (\text{WE})$$

- (a) Graph $f(x)$ and $g(x)$ by hand.

Solution —



(b) Find the solution of (WE) for $x \in \mathbb{R}, t > 0$ with

$$u(0, x) = f(x) \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(0, x) = 0$$

for $x \in \mathbb{R}$. In particular, write the solution in terms of the $f(x)$ function. Then, graph by hand $u(\frac{1}{c}, x)$, $u(\frac{2}{c}, x)$, and $u(\frac{3}{c}, x)$ using different axes.

Solution — To find the general solution of (WE), apply the substitution

$$\begin{aligned} r(t, x) &= x - ct \\ s(t, x) &= x + ct \end{aligned}$$

Assume $u(t, x) = U(r, s)$ is a solution and substitute (we first calculate the needed derivatives of u):

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x} &= \frac{\partial U}{\partial r} \frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial U}{\partial s} \frac{\partial s}{\partial x} \\ &= \frac{\partial U}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial U}{\partial s} \end{aligned}$$

And

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{\partial U}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial U}{\partial s} \right)$$

To simplify further, note that $\frac{\partial U}{\partial r}$ is some function of r and s , say $\phi_1(r, s)$, and $\frac{\partial U}{\partial s}$ is also some function of r and s , say $\phi_2(r, s)$:

$$\begin{aligned} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x} (\phi_1(r, s) + \phi_2(r, s)) \\ &= \frac{\partial \phi_1}{\partial r} \frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \phi_1}{\partial s} \frac{\partial s}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \phi_2}{\partial r} \frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial \phi_2}{\partial s} \frac{\partial s}{\partial x} \\ &= \frac{\partial \phi_1}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial \phi_1}{\partial s} + \frac{\partial \phi_2}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial \phi_2}{\partial s} \\ &= \frac{\partial}{\partial r} \left(\frac{\partial U}{\partial r} \right) + \frac{\partial}{\partial s} \left(\frac{\partial U}{\partial r} \right) + \frac{\partial}{\partial r} \left(\frac{\partial U}{\partial s} \right) + \frac{\partial}{\partial s} \left(\frac{\partial U}{\partial s} \right) \\ &= \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r^2} + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s \partial r} + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s^2} \end{aligned}$$

Let us assume that $U(r, s)$ is smooth and well-behaved enough for the cross-derivatives to be equal. Then

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} = \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r^2} + 2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} \right) + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s^2}$$

By similar mechanics, we obtain

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial t^2} = c^2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r^2} - 2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} \right) + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s^2} \right)$$

Substituting these second derivatives in the general wave equation yields:

$$\begin{aligned} & \left[c^2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r^2} - 2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} \right) + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s^2} \right) \right] \\ & - c^2 \left[\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r^2} + 2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} \right) + \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial s^2} \right] \\ & = -4c^2 \left(\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} \right) = 0 \\ & \iff \frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial r \partial s} = 0 \end{aligned}$$

Our change-of-variables has transformed the original wave equation into this more workable form, which we can now simply integrate to extract U :

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial r} \frac{\partial U}{\partial s} = 0$$

$$\iff \frac{\partial U}{\partial s} = C_1(s)$$

$$\iff U = C_2(s) + C_3(r)$$

$$\iff U(r, s) = F(r) + G(s)$$

$$\iff u(t, x) = F(x - ct) + G(x + ct)$$

We now apply our initial conditions.

$$u(0, x) = f(x) \implies F(x) + G(x) = f(x)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \left. \frac{\partial u}{\partial t} \right|_{(0, x)} = 0 &\implies -cF'(x) + cG'(x) = 0 \\ &\implies F'(x) = G'(x) \\ &\implies F(x) = G(x) + \delta \quad \text{for some } \delta \in \mathbb{R} \end{aligned}$$

Our two constraints combine to imply

$$\begin{aligned} 2G(x) + \delta &= f(x) \\ \implies G(x) &= \frac{1}{2}(f(x) - \delta) \\ \implies F(x) &= \frac{1}{2}(f(x) + \delta) \end{aligned}$$

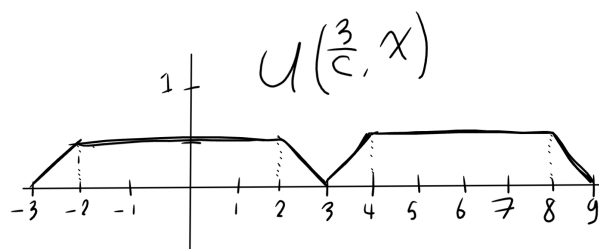
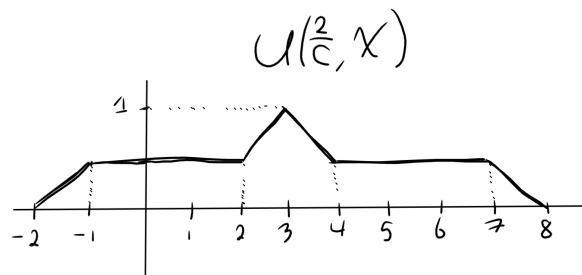
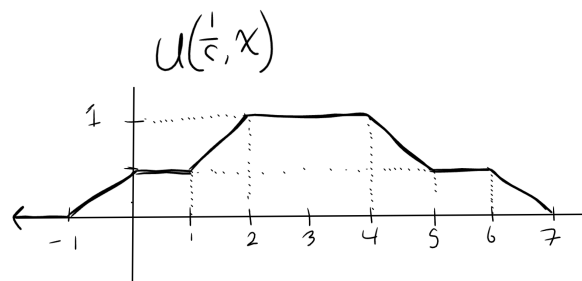
Hence

$$\begin{aligned} u(t, x) &= \frac{1}{2}(f(x - ct) + \delta) + \frac{1}{2}(f(x + ct) - \delta) \\ &= \boxed{\frac{1}{2}f(x - ct) + \frac{1}{2}f(x + ct)} \end{aligned}$$

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} u\left(\frac{1}{c}, x\right) &= \frac{1}{2}f(x - 1) + \frac{1}{2}f(x + 1) \\ u\left(\frac{2}{c}, x\right) &= \frac{1}{2}f(x - 2) + \frac{1}{2}f(x + 2) \\ u\left(\frac{3}{c}, x\right) &= \frac{1}{2}f(x - 3) + \frac{1}{2}f(x + 3) \end{aligned}}$$

(c) Find the solution of (WE) for $x \in \mathbb{R}, t > 0$ with

$$u(0, x) = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(0, x) = g(x)$$



for $x \in \mathbb{R}$. In particular, write the solution in terms of the $g(x)$ function. Then, graph by hand $u(\frac{1}{c}, x)$, $u(\frac{2}{c}, x)$, and $u(\frac{3}{c}, x)$ using different axes.

Solution — Now we apply different initial conditions to the same general solution we obtained $u(t, x) = F(x - ct) + G(x + ct)$:

$$u(0, x) = 0 \implies F(x) = -G(x)$$

$$\left. \frac{\partial u}{\partial t} \right|_{(0, x)} = g(x) \implies -cF'(x) + cG'(x) = g(x)$$

From our first constraint, $F'(x) = -G'(x)$, so

$$-c(-G'(x)) + cG'(x) = g(x)$$

$$G'(x) = \frac{g(x)}{2c}$$

$$G(x) = \frac{1}{2c} \int g(x) dx + \delta$$

$$F(x) = -\frac{1}{2c} \int g(x) dx - \delta$$

Let $A(x)$ be the antiderivative of g , so that $A'(x) = g(x)$:

$$G(x) = \frac{1}{2c} A(x) + \delta \quad F(x) = -\frac{1}{2c} A(x) - \delta$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned} u(t, x) &= \left(-\frac{1}{2c} A(x - ct) - \delta \right) + \left(\frac{1}{2c} A(x + ct) + \delta \right) \\ &= \frac{1}{2c} \left(A(x + ct) - A(x - ct) \right) \\ &= \boxed{\frac{1}{2c} \int_{x-ct}^{x+ct} g(\zeta) d\zeta} \end{aligned}$$

We compute a few solution functions at various times. First, note that the area under g from a to b is

$$A(x) = \begin{cases} 0, & \text{if } x < -1 \\ x + 1, & \text{if } |x| < 1 \\ 2, & \text{if } x > 1 \end{cases}$$

Now, at different time increments $\frac{n}{c}$ for $n = 1, 2, 3 \dots$, the solution is

$$\begin{aligned}
u\left(\frac{n}{c}, x\right) &= \frac{1}{2c} \int_{x-n}^{x+n} g(\zeta) d\zeta \\
&= \frac{1}{2c} \left(A(x+n) - A(x-n) \right) \\
&= \frac{1}{2c} \left(\begin{cases} 0, & \text{if } x+n < -1 \\ (x+n)+1, & \text{if } |x+n| < 1 \\ 2, & \text{if } x+n > 1 \end{cases} - \begin{cases} 0, & \text{if } x-n < -1 \\ (x-n)+1, & \text{if } |x-n| < 1 \\ 2, & \text{if } x-n > 1 \end{cases} \right) \\
&= \frac{1}{2c} \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } x \leq -n-1 \\ n+1+x, & \text{if } -n-1 \leq x \leq -n+1 \\ 2, & \text{if } -n+1 \leq x < n-1 \\ n+1-x, & \text{if } n-1 \leq x \leq n+1 \\ 0, & \text{if } x \geq n+1 \end{cases}
\end{aligned}$$

Consider the symmetry of the $n+1+x$ and $n+1-x$ cases. If we apply the substitution $A = n-1$ and $B = n+1$, then these cases reduce to

$$\begin{cases} B+x & \text{if } -B \leq x \leq -A \\ B-x & \text{if } A \leq x \leq B \end{cases}$$

Which reduces to

$$\begin{cases} B-|x| & \text{if } A \leq |x| \leq B \end{cases}$$

(Note that $B+x = B-|x|$ when x is negative (in the first interval) and $B-x = B-|x|$ when x is positive (in the second interval)). Also note that the two zero cases can be described by $|x| \geq n+1$. Hence

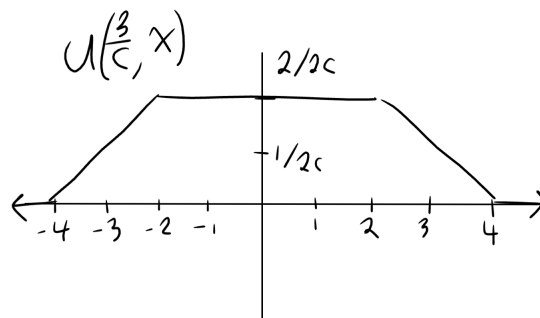
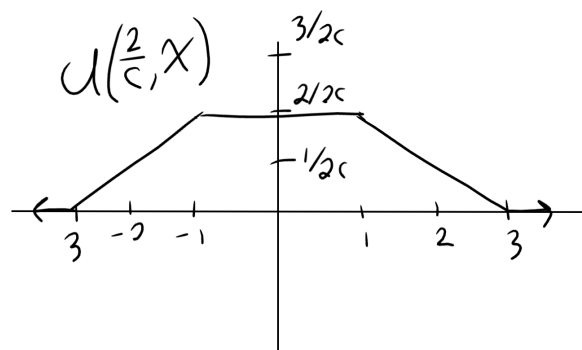
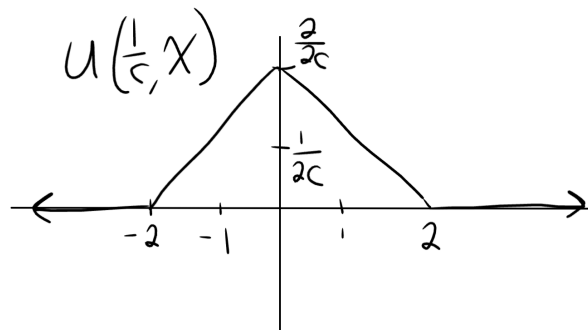
$$u\left(\frac{n}{c}, x\right) = \frac{1}{2c} \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } |x| \geq n+1 \\ n+1-|x| & \text{if } n-1 \leq |x| \leq n+1 \\ 2 & \text{if } |x| \leq n-1 \end{cases}$$

Hence

$$u\left(\frac{1}{c}, x\right) = \frac{1}{2c} \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } |x| \geq 2 \\ 2-|x| & \text{if } 0 \leq |x| \leq 2 \end{cases}$$

$$u\left(\frac{2}{c}, x\right) = \frac{1}{2c} \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } |x| \geq 3 \\ 3-|x| & \text{if } 1 \leq |x| \leq 3 \\ 2 & \text{if } |x| \leq 1 \end{cases}$$

$$u\left(\frac{3}{c}, x\right) = \frac{1}{2c} \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } |x| \geq 4 \\ 4 - |x| & \text{if } 2 \leq |x| \leq 4 \\ 2 & \text{if } |x| \leq 2 \end{cases}$$



2. (12 points) Let $f, g \in PC^1[0, L]$ be given continuous functions. Find the solution of (WE) for $0 < x < L$ and $t > 0$ with the boundary conditions

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, 0) = \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, L) = 0, \quad t > 0$$

and the initial conditions for $0 < x < L$

$$u(0, x) = f(x), \quad \frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(0, x) = g(x).$$

Solution — Since we now impose boundary conditions (in addition to initial conditions), we must now solve the wave equation on a bounded domain, which requires separation of variables. We assume the solution takes the separated form

$$u(t, x) = T(t)X(x)$$

For all $t, x \in \mathbb{R}$. Then

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial t^2} = T''(t)X(x) \quad \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} = T(t)X''(x)$$

and the wave equation takes the form

$$T''(t)X(x) - c^2 T(t)X''(x) = 0 \implies \frac{T''(t)}{T(t)} = c^2 \frac{X''(x)}{X(x)}$$

which is of the form $F(t) = G(x)$. Because we're assuming this equality holds for all x, t , then both sides of the equation must be constant (fix $x = x_0$ and we have $F(t) = G(x_0)$, which is equivalent to saying that $F(t)$ is (in general) equal to some constant $G(x_0)$. The same can be deduced by fixing $t = t_0$). Let λ be this constant:

$$\frac{T''(t)}{T(t)} = c^2 \frac{X''(x)}{X(x)} = \lambda \implies \begin{cases} T'' - \lambda T = 0 \\ c^2 X'' - \lambda X = 0 \end{cases}$$

This is a system of independent second-order homogeneous linear ODEs, each of which can be solved with the characteristic equation to obtain the solutions

$$\begin{aligned} T(t) &= c_1 e^{-\sqrt{\lambda}t} + c_2 e^{\sqrt{\lambda}t} \\ X(x) &= c_2 e^{-\frac{\sqrt{\lambda}}{c}x} + c_3 e^{\frac{\sqrt{\lambda}}{c}x} \end{aligned}$$

When $\lambda > 0$, or

$$\begin{aligned} T(t) &= A + Bt \\ X(x) &= C + Dx \end{aligned}$$

When $\lambda = 0$, or

$$\begin{aligned} T(t) &= A_1 \cos(\sqrt{-\lambda}t) + B_1 \sin(\sqrt{-\lambda}t) \\ X(x) &= C_1 \cos\left(\frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}x\right) + D_1 \sin\left(\frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}x\right) \end{aligned}$$

When $\lambda < 0$. We will now apply our boundary conditions

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, 0) = \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, L) = 0$$

Note that these are Neumann boundary conditions because they fix the physical slope of the string in space at the boundaries (as opposed to fixing the position of the string in space with Dirichlet boundaries).

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, 0) = T(t)X'(x) \big|_{(t,0)} = T(t)X'(0) = 0$$

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, L) = T(t)X'(x) \big|_{(t,L)} = T(t)X'(L) = 0$$

For $\lambda > 0$: Ignoring the trivial case where $T(t) = 0$ (which causes the wave solution $u(t, x) = T(t)X(x)$ to be zero everywhere), these initial conditions reduce to

$$\begin{aligned} X'(0) = 0 & \quad X'(L) = 0 \\ \implies c_2 = c_3 & \quad \implies -c_2 e^{\frac{-\sqrt{\lambda}}{c}L} + c_3 e^{\frac{\sqrt{\lambda}}{c}L} = 0 \\ & \quad \implies c_3 \left[2 \sinh \frac{\sqrt{\lambda}}{c} L \right] = 0 \\ & \quad \implies c_3 = 0 \quad (\text{because } \lambda \neq 0, c \neq 0, L \neq 0) \\ & \quad \implies c_2 = 0 \end{aligned}$$

$$\implies X(x) = 0 \implies u(t, x) = 0$$

For $\lambda = 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} X'(0) = 0 & \quad X'(L) = 0 \\ \implies D = 0 & \quad \implies D = 0 \\ & \quad \implies X(x) = C \\ & \quad \implies u(t, x) = C(A + Bt) \end{aligned}$$

For $\lambda < 0$:

$$\begin{aligned}
X'(0) = 0 & \quad X'(L) = 0 \\
\implies \frac{D_1 \sqrt{-\lambda}}{c} = 0 & \quad \implies -C_1 \sin\left(\frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}L\right) + D_1 \cos\left(\frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}L\right) = 0 \\
\implies D_1 = 0 \quad (\text{since } \lambda \neq 0, c \neq 0) & \quad \implies C_1 \sin\left(\frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}L\right) = 0 \quad (\text{substituting } D_1 = 0) \\
& \quad \implies \frac{\sqrt{-\lambda}}{c}L = n\pi \quad (\text{For nontrivial } C_1 \neq 0) \\
& \quad \implies \lambda_n = -\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}\right)^2
\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned}
T(t) &= A_1 \cos\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) + B_1 \sin\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) \\
X(x) &= C_1 \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right)
\end{aligned}$$

and

$$u(t, x) = \left[A_1 \cos\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) + B_1 \sin\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) \right] C_1 \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right)$$

By linearity of the wave equation, the superposition principle states that the general solution is the sum of all separated solution modes. Hence, the provided Neumann boundary conditions lead to the following general solution (over all possible λ)

$$u(t, x) = a_0 + b_0 t + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \left[a_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) + b_n \sin\left(\frac{n\pi c}{L}t\right) \right] \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right)$$

We now apply the initial conditions:

$$\begin{aligned}
u(0, x) = f(x) & \implies a_0 + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} a_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right) = f(x) \\
\left. \frac{\partial u}{\partial t} \right|_{(0, x)} = g(x) & \implies b_0 + \left(\frac{\pi c}{L}\right) \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} n b_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right) = g(x)
\end{aligned}$$

Hence our a_n coefficients must be exactly the cosine-series coefficients of the Fourier expansion of $f(x)$:

$$\begin{aligned}
a_0 &= \frac{1}{L} \int_0^L f(x) dx \\
a_n &= \frac{2}{L} \int_0^L f(x) \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{L}\right) dx
\end{aligned}$$

3. (15 points) Assume $u(t, x)$ satisfies (WE) for $0 < x < L$ and $t > 0$ and define

$$\mathcal{E}(t) = \frac{1}{2} \int_0^L \left| \frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(t, x) \right|^2 dx + \frac{1}{2} c^2 \int_0^L \left| \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, x) \right|^2 dx$$

to be the associated total energy, where the first term in $\mathcal{E}(t)$ represents the kinetic energy and the second represents the potential energy.

- (a) Use **integration by parts** to show that the total energy satisfies

$$\mathcal{E}'(t) = c^2 \frac{\partial u}{\partial t}(t, x) \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, x) \Big|_{x=0}^{x=L}.$$

Solution —

- (b) Show that the energy is conserved, meaning $\mathcal{E}(t) = \mathcal{E}(0)$ for all $t \geq 0$, for the zero Neumann boundary condition, namely assume that for $t \geq 0$

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, 0) = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(t, L) = 0.$$

Solution —

- (c) Show that the energy is conserved for any Dirichlet boundary conditions, namely for given $A, B \in \mathbb{R}$ assume that for $t \geq 0$

$$u(t, 0) = A \quad \text{and} \quad u(t, L) = B.$$

Solution —

- (d) Show that the potential energy and kinetic energy are equal for a traveling wave solution

$$u(t, x) = v(x - ct)$$

where v is a sufficiently smooth function.

Solution —

4. (8 points) Maxwell's equations for electric $E(t, x)$ and magnetic $B(t, x)$ fields in a vacuum are

$$\begin{cases} \frac{\partial B}{\partial t} + \nabla \times E = 0 \\ \mu_0 \epsilon_0 \frac{\partial E}{\partial t} - \nabla \times B = 0 \\ \nabla \cdot E = \nabla \cdot B = 0 \end{cases}$$

where $\mu_0 > 0$ is the permeability of free space and $\epsilon_0 > 0$ is the permittivity of free space. Using the “curl-curl” identity

$$\nabla \times (\nabla \times \phi) = \nabla (\nabla \cdot \phi) - \Delta \phi$$

for any $\phi(x)$, show that both E and B satisfy the (vector) wave equation

$$\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial t^2} - c^2 \Delta u = 0$$

and determine the associated speed of propagation c . Here, $\Delta \phi = \nabla \cdot (\nabla \phi)$ is the Laplacian of ϕ , which represents a generalization of the second derivative in higher dimensions.

Solution —